Estelle El-Hai Word Count: 503
Writers' Group-June submission

It Had to be Me

"Get your Lucky Strike Hit Parade song sheet, five cents," hawked the young boys on Pitkin Avenue in Brooklyn, New York. I looked forward to these wonderful lyrics, which included the introductions as well as the refrains. The words were so meaningful, so full of rapture, so romantic! My friends and I memorized all the verses and often sang them on the way to high school.

If you were lucky, your dance partner not only smelled good, but also knew some of the words, and would whisper them into your ear with his hot breath. Those were the days. Beautiful pictures were indelibly painted into your memory as these poems of love were crooned by Frank Sinatra, Perry Como and Dick Haymes. And you knew they were meant only for you.

The excitement of the big band music was shared by an entire generation. It was emotional and personal. To this day, these golden oldies, trigger strong feelings of youth and joy, as the scent of a gardenia or a fragrant rose does. They are co-mingled with rays of creativity which have always captured me in the very early hours of the morning, when I am almost awake. This rush of warmth enveloped me frequently over the years and I prayed that the glow of energy would be with me always.

We now fast-forward to my recent trip to Minneapolis, where I enjoyed visiting with my youngest son, Jack, his wife, Ann, and their two adorable daughters, Natalie, three and a half, and her kid sister, Sasha, almost two. What a great little family; we had such fun. We played, we sang, we read stories, we danced and we talked.

The day before I left for home, I excused myself from a game

saying, "Just a few minutes girls, Bubby doesn't feel good." Actually, Bubby (grandmother) was feeling rotten. I isolated myself in the guest room and spent the entire day fighting the flu. I couldn't tolerate any food or fluid all day. Although I was encouraged to stay an additional day, I wanted to go home and recuperate in my own bed.

In the plane, I curled up against the window and endured the longest, hottest flight imaginable. At home, my suspicion was confirmed, and the thermometer registered at one hundred and one degrees. I kept thinking of melons, oranges and seltzer and knew I needed fluids and a morale booster. My inspiration was a CD of wonderful music. It filled my mind, but not my body yet. Where was that glow of energy, that warm (cool would have been better!) current of inspiration and vitality? Where was that feeling of Me?

Two days later, it seeped in. I awoke feeling refreshed and elated again. Life was good. There were things to do and places to go. There were friends and flowers, birds and songs. The sun was shining and it was good to be me again.

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